Listening Skills

Outline

- Definition of listening
- The process of listening- three phases…
- Types of listening
- Barriers in the listening process
- Note taking

What is listening

- It is a process of making sense of what is being heard, i.e. trying to understand what one hears. In other words, listening is a mental process that requires concentrating on sound, deriving meaning from it and reacting to it.
- Listening is an intentional process, thus, it requires developing specific skills and attitudes to be effective listeners.
- Listening differs from hearing.

Hearing defined

- Hearing is defined as a sense that allows you to perceive sound. It is a physical act that requires only the reception of sound waves.
- It is a passive process hence you often hear even when you don’t want to. It implies no intention from the “receiver” of the communication.

Listening is an active process

- Listening is an active process. It might begin with hearing but it goes beyond the use of one of the senses.
- Listening is an intentional act. It thus requires some effort and concentration. A good listener mentally processes what is s/he hears with concentration on sound heard in order to derive meaning from it and react to it.

Why is listening important?

- In any community, people spend most of their time listening compared to other communicative activities. The same situation prevails at work places as well as in academic institutions. For communication to occur, listening must take place. In fact feedback is, primarily, triggered by listening. When we talk to each other, we process both verbal and nonverbal messages. We receive many messages and, we attend to some of them and assign a variety of meanings to those messages. We are listeners during most of the times that we are awake.

The Listening Process

- It consists of three phases which are ***awareness, reception*** and ***perception.***

i) Awareness:

- It starts with the receiver becoming aware that s/he should listen and becoming attentive to what is being said.
- Once listeners are attentive to the message, they are in the right frame of mind to listen- to be receptive of what is being said.

ii) Reception

- It is the act of physically hearing the message through the senses of hearing and sight.
- We hear through our ears and also use our eyes to observe non-verbal signals.
- Once people are aware (attentive) and reception has taken place, they can begin to perceive.

iii) Perception

- This entails interpreting what has reached the brains through the sense of hearing and sight.
- It entails understanding the message and judging the value of the sound that reaches the ears or what our eyes see.

Developing Awareness

- To develop awareness both the sender and the receiver have some responsibilities.

Sender's responsibilities

- Motivate the receiver by adapting the message to meet his or her goals, objectives and needs.
- Arouse curiosity by telling jokes or telling humorous stories.
- Speak loudly and clearly enough for the receiver to hear you.
- Ask questions to cause receivers think about what you are saying. This forces them to participate and be attentive.

Sender's responsibilities cont…

- Avoid barriers to listening process-
- **Physical (external)barriers:**

✓ Can drown the message

✓ Can distract the sender and make him/her forget what was being said.

✓ Can distract the listener and refrain him/her from capturing what is being said.

Avoid barriers cont…

- **Verbal barriers-**

✓ Use vocabulary that is on the receiver's level.

✓ Explain any technical words

✓ Avoid jargons

- **Emotional barriers**

✓ Speak with confidence

✓ Avoid harshness

Receiver's Responsibilities

- Compensate for any physical hearing problems by:
- ✓ Moving in closer
- ✓ Sitting in front row rather than at the back
- ✓ Asking the sender to raise his/her voice
- Get ready to listen- be in the right posture for listening, straighten up and face the speaker. There is a connection between the body and the mind.

Receiver's Responsibilities cont…

- Concentrate on what is being said and. Direct all your thoughts to what is being said.
- Keep an open mind. Avoid blocking out ideas you do not like or want to hear. Avoid the tendency to resist ideas of no personal interest and jumping to hasty conclusions.
- Avoid mind wandering- avoid being carried away by your thoughts.

Receiver's Responsibilities Cont…

- Use extra thinking to summarise and analyse what is being said:
- ✓ Listen for ideas and meanings
- ✓ Understand key ideas behind the words and details presented to you.
- ✓ Listen to semantic/transitional markers the speaker uses in order to understand fully what is being said.

Reception (the act of physically hearing the message through senses)

- Direct all your attention to what is being said. Do not give room to any other thoughts.
- Listen with more than one sense- observe the sender's non-verbal cues: facial expressions, gestures, pauses, tone, of the voice, emphasis etc
- Be an active listener- ask questions, answer questions, comment, constructively, criticise, give example i.e. personal instances

Reception cont…

- Hold your fire- don’t be quick in expressing your opinion on what you hear. You should hold your opinion to the end of what is being said at a particular time so that you can gather enough information to enable you make correct evaluation(judgement).
- Try to concentrate on what is being said rather than react to it.
- Judge the content and not the delivery.

Perception

- Despite being the last phase in the listening process, perception is the most significant phase because it is at this stage most of our problems in listening occur.

Factors that promote perception

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Types of Listening

1. Listening for Pleasure and Enjoyment

- Listening for pleasure takes place when we listen to music, TV, or radio as a pass time activity. It does not require much concentration. In fact in the case of music, we rarely listen to each and every word, phrase or sentence. Such words are easily missed and pass without noticing them. They are seldom meant to be remembered or recorded. A similar situation applies to talk shows. The only difference here is that one has to listen to the flow of the talk by being part of the communication otherwise you run the risk of losing out on the entertainment or amusement. The common feature in all such situations is that listening for enjoyment requires very little involvement in the communication process.

2. Listening for Information

- This type of listening requires more concentration than listening for enjoyment. This is the case, for instance, when you listen to a class discussion or to an informative speech. As a student you frequently need to apply this type of listening mainly in preparation for examinations or tests. The general objective is to be able to store or recall the information for future use. It is similar to listening to instructions on how to get to Mzimba from Lilongwe for example. Retention of such information becomes necessary for one to reach the destination. A similar example is listening to a training session. Contrast this with listening to an explanation of how your friend escaped a near fatal car accident.

3. Critical Listening

- Critical listening is more than just listening for information. It involves analyzing and evaluating information. When a Police constable is investigating a crime by interrogating a suspect he goes beyond mere listening with the purpose of recording or recalling the information. He aims at discovering more than what is said by the suspect. Depending on the subject at hand, a researcher may also do the same when collecting information for a study. Some Students apply this type of listening from time to time, especially when listening to instructions and explanation on how to conduct a scientific experiment in a laboratory. Another example of critical listening is when interviewing a potential employee.

4. Precision Listening

- When we are involved in listening to details for clues to the speaker's feelings or state of mind, we go beyond critical listening. The objective here is not just to get the facts but also the subtle messages and feelings conveyed through the quality of voice or facial expression. This is called listening with precision or exactness with the ability to distinguish clearly. What matters in such cases is not only what is said but also how it is said. To a precision listener, both the substance and the style are important.

5. Empathic Listening

- This is the most advanced type of listening. It needs concentration, retention and judgment. It also requires “the ability to put yourself in someone else’s place and understand his or her feelings.” This is called empathy, which requires the skills of a precision listener motivated to listen for an understanding of how the speaker feels.

Qualities of an empathic listener

- S/he does not rush to offer a personal opinion
- Is capable of withstanding emotions that are difficult to talk about
- Is capable of suspending judgment and ready to offer opinions when asked
- Understands and recognizes the choice for others to talk and respects the role of a listener
- Respects the feelings of others without necessarily agreeing with those feelings

Overcoming barriers to listening

- A listening barrier is any physical, mental or cultural condition that reduces the likelihood of a message to be received and understood as intended. When this happens, interference of effective communication takes place. Once listening barriers are reduced, communication becomes more effective. It is, therefore, important to understand listening barriers so as to avoid them.
- Barriers to effective listening include: physical barriers, mental barriers, attitudes and cultural barriers.

Physical Barriers to Listening

- Physical barriers to listening constitute anything that interferes with the hearing itself. Where there is loss of hearing be it partial or total, listening cannot take place. A poor audio system can also cause a physical barrier to listening. It is important to note that both listeners and speakers share responsibility for good listening by avoiding such barriers.

Mental Barriers to Listening

- A wandering mind or inattention that result into lack of concentration represent the most common mental barrier. Thus mental barriers to listening are more difficult to deal with. Such barriers make our minds wander when we are listening.
- It has been demonstrated that most speakers communicate at 125-250 words per minute against our brains that process words at over 500 words per minute. This is especially so when we listen for information, criticism, precision and empathy.

Attitudes in Listening

- Attitudes refer to beliefs or feelings we have about ourselves, other people, ideas and events. In other words, it is a state of mind about something or someone.
- Naturally, an audience with a hostile or apathetic attitude, is most likely to experience listening problems. A good example is in a class where students have a negative attitude about a topic, subject or tutor; listening is likely to be negatively affected.

Attitudes in Listening cont…

- Selective listening also sometimes stems from an attitude problem of blocking out anything we don't want to hear and pay attention to information that coincides with our beliefs. This also can result into a barrier to listening.

Attitudes in Listening cont…

- Sometimes a listener's personal attitude makes him jump into conclusions before the speaker has concluded what s/he has to say. Sometimes we think we know what another person will or is about to say and we interrupt or jump to a conclusion. We assume we know the other person's intention based on how we felt. Hence the cliché "I know what you are going to say." Most of the times our guess is wrong! The way to deal with this problem is to learn to be patient. We must learn to listen to the entire message before responding. Such patience or "holding fire" allows us to base our conclusion on all of the information instead of part of it.

Cultural Barriers to Listening

- Cultural barriers readily manifest in language, dialect or accent differences. It is thus important to be sensitive to such differences to be able to listen effectively. The obligation to overcome such barriers rests with the speaker as well.
- Native speakers of English, for instance, find it difficult to listen to non-native speakers due to accents. It requires more concentration to barrier is to listen for overall content rather than trying to understand each specific word that is said.

Cultural Barriers in Listening cont…

- Even within the same linguistic community, the use of certain words in English is considered rude by those in other cultures. For instance, to some cultures “hey” is a greeting similar to “hi” or “hello.” To some English speakers, “hey” is a means of getting someone’s attention in a rude way. Hence using the word “hey” can be a barrier to listening if it is interpreted as rudeness rather than a friendly greeting.